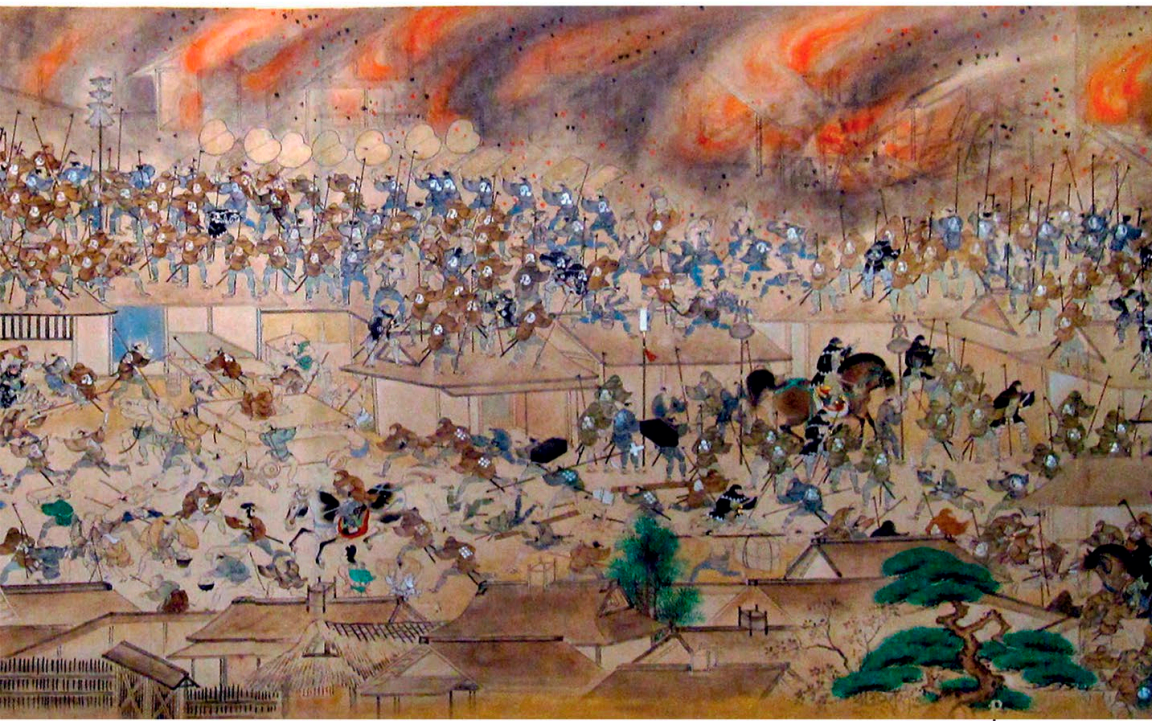




1657

GREAT FIRE OF MEIREKI

With tightly packed houses built of wood and paper, the Japanese capital Edo (modern-day Tokyo) was notably vulnerable to fire. In March 1657, a huge conflagration – the Great Fire of Meireki – broke out, started by a burning kimono. Around 100,000 people are said to have died in three days when two-thirds of the city was destroyed by fire.

◁ The Great Fire, scroll painting, 1814

1655 Poland's "Deluge" begins when Swedish armies under King Charles X invade the Polish-Lithuanian Commonwealth

1656 The Ottoman Empire revives under the brutal but effective Köprülü viziers

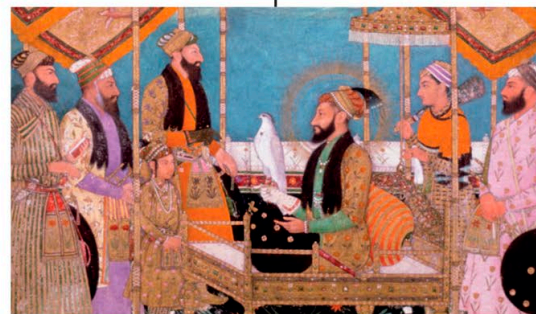
1659

1656
ACCURATE TIME

Dutch scientist Christiaan Huygens (1629–95) was a leading figure in many fields, from astronomy to optics. In 1656, developing an idea proposed by Galileo Galilei, he devised the first pendulum clock. Built to Huygens's design by clockmaker Salomon Coster, it kept time far more accurately than any previous mechanism. Precise timekeeping eventually transformed daily life.



△ Christiaan Huygens' pendulum clock



△ Emperor Aurangzeb in his court

1658

AURANGZEB SEIZES POWER

As Mughal Emperor Shah Jahan grew old and ill, his four sons fought for control of India. In 1658, the third son, Aurangzeb, emerged victorious. He killed two of his brothers and placed his father under arrest. Ruling for 49 years, Aurangzeb expanded the empire, but his Muslim beliefs led to conflict with some of his subjects.

Under Aurangzeb the Mughal Empire expanded to 4 million sq km (1.5 million sq miles)